

Songwriter's Number System Cheat Sheet

Unlock 90% of Popular Songs • Instant Transposition • Major Scale Harmony

The Songwriter's Core Shortcut: Instead of memorizing hundreds of static chord shapes across different keys, write and transpose using **scale numbers**. Learn a progression once by number, and you can instantly play it in any key or capo position to fit your vocal range.

1. MAJOR SCALE FORMULA & NASHVILLE CHORD MAP

Key	1 (I)	2 (ii)	3 (iii)	4 (IV)	5 (V)	6 (vi)	7 (vii°)
QUALITY	MAJOR	MINOR	MINOR	MAJOR	MAJOR	MINOR	DIM
Key of G	G	Am	Bm	C	D	Em	F#dim
Key of C	C	Dm	Em	F	G	Am	Bdim
Key of D	D	Em	F#m	G	A	Bm	C#dim
Key of A	A	Bm	C#m	D	E	F#m	G#dim
Key of E	E	F#m	G#m	A	B	C#m	D#dim

2. ESSENTIAL HIT BLUEPRINTS

- 1 – 5 – 6m – 4 The Universal Anthem**

The driving engine behind modern pop/rock hits. Emotional, memorable, and immediately familiar.
- 1 – 4 – 5 – 4 The Folk / Storyteller**

Grounded and open; leaves maximum space for lyric phrasing. Alternate with **1 – 4 – 1 – 5** for verses.
- 6m – 4 – 1 – 5 The Indie Tension Loop**

Starts on the relative minor to build moodiness before resolving into a bright, open major chorus.
- 1 – 4 – 1 – 5 – 1 The Americana / Blues**

Traditional harmonic movement with solid resolution at every measure turnaround.

3. RULE OF THUMB

- 1. Anchor with the 1 Chord:** The **1 chord** represents "home". To build unresolved narrative tension, avoid landing on the 1 during verses.
- 2. 4 vs. 5 Momentum:** The **4 chord** provides uplifting lift (great for pre-choruses); the **5 chord** creates peak harmonic pull back to 1.
- 3. Relative Minor (6m):** Swapping 1 with 6m shifts the vibe between optimism and melancholy without changing keys.
- 4. Capo Shortcut:** Master open **G** or **C** shapes; slide a capo to shift keys for any vocal range without relearning fingerings.

Want to Master Songwriting & Fretboard Theory?

Join the upcoming 4-Week **Guitar for Songwriting** cohort with Luke Moore at Scenic Route Music LLC. Practical chord building, melody harmonization & lyric arrangement.

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